

Wondering if you two are already exclusive

9 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

You don't know until one of you **says it**. Staying vague reads as its own signal to the other person, often as a test of whether they're ready to commit.

THE GOAL

You're finding out where you stand on purpose, not waiting to feel sure without asking. Say your own position first, in plain words, and let them answer.

CHECKLIST

You've decided you want to have this conversation, and you're looking for the moment to start it.

- ☐ Choose a moment when it's just the two of you: not mid-argument, not right after sex, not with other people around.
- ☐ Put your phone somewhere you won't glance at it once you start.
- ☐ If you're about to send a hint or a delayed reply to test them instead of asking outright, ask the direct question instead.
- ☐ Say where you stand first, in plain words: "I've stopped wanting to see anyone else, and wanted to say it out loud."
- ☐ Ask directly what they want, in words: "Where are you at with that?"
- ☐ Sort their answer into a clear yes, or anything less than a clear yes, like "let me think" or silence.
- ☐ If it's a yes, agree out loud on what changes now, like telling friends or closing dating apps.
- ☐ If it's a yes, close or pause your dating profiles before the day is out.
- ☐ If it's anything less than a yes, ask what would help them decide, rather than guessing for them.
- ☐ If it's anything less than a yes, agree a check-in point, like "let's talk again in two weeks," and wait for it.
- ☐ Write down what was said, somewhere you'll see it again.
- ☐ If the answer wasn't what you hoped, decide what you're doing about it now, rather than letting it quietly reopen in a week.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** The quiet isn't neutral. For many, it's a test of whether **they're ready to commit**.
- 2** Staying vague isn't just uncomfortable, it's measurable. Couples who felt clear on who they were, tracked for nine months, were less likely to break up, an effect the researchers called preliminary given how few couples in the study actually split.
- 3** Most people who ask already have a good read on their partner's feelings. The conversation mostly confirms what they sensed.

What the quiet is doing

KNOW

The quiet isn't neutral. For many, it's a test of whether **they're ready to commit**.

If that's what's happening, the fix isn't more time, it's naming what you're unsure about out loud. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Quiet on both sides doesn't mean whoever cares less stays quieter. Uncertainty makes people less likely to raise it.

Uncertainty makes silence more likely on both sides, so their quiet is probably the same fear as yours. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't assume it's obvious to them. People are reliably wrong about how much their feelings show.

Feeling sure something's obvious is exactly the state this bias runs on, so it's worth saying anyway. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Feeling stuck on when to ask isn't unusual. **Over half** of people who found their last relationship hard to define pointed to not being sure what their partner was hoping for.

Not knowing what a partner wants is the top reason people give for staying undefined, and asking closes it. [Source 4](#)

What staying undefined is costing you

KNOW

Staying vague isn't just uncomfortable, it's measurable. Couples who felt clear on who they were, tracked for nine months, were less likely to break up, an effect the researchers called preliminary given how few couples in the study actually split.

Feeling unclear wasn't just a mood, it went with whether couples were still together nine months later. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Quietly agreeing with a partner isn't the same as feeling clear about where you stand. Feeling clear about the relationship went with commitment even after accounting for whether partners privately agreed.

Agreement and clarity turned out to be separate things, and it was clarity that linked to commitment. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

Texting constantly can make things feel safe without making them real. Situationships showed lower trust than defined relationships across most kinds of contact, though heavy texting alone nudged how safe partners felt.

Frequent texting raises how safe things feel, but the trust gap underneath stays the same. [Source 4](#)

What happens once you ask

KNOW

Most people who ask already have a good read on their partner's feelings. The conversation mostly confirms what they sensed.

So you don't need proof before asking, you likely already have the answer in your own gut. [Source 2](#)

DO

Bring up the future loosely, even before you're ready for the full talk. Doing that was linked to less anxiety.

Talking about the future, even loosely, was linked to less anxiety and more sense the relationship could go somewhere. [Source 1](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Staying quiet and not asking keeps your options open, it's safer than risking a clear answer.

ACTUALLY

Avoiding the conversation doesn't preserve anything. Couples who let a milestone happen without ever choosing it together end up **worse off** than couples who talked it through. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.psypost.org/new-psychology-research-reveals-why-people-stay-in-situationships/>
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3. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Illusion_of_transparency
4. <https://www.goldencubclub.com/news/situationships-trust-langlais-hinge-2026>
5. https://elifinkel.squarespace.com/s/EmeryGardnerCarswellFinkel2021_PSPB.pdf
6. <https://vanulos.com/en/blog/sliding-vs-deciding-relationship-research>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on The early months at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)